GRE Issue Essay Planning Template

The 30-Minute Issue Essay Architecture, The 6.0 Scoring Rubric, Paragraph Frameworks & Editing Checklist

1. The 30-Minute Analytical Writing Issue Essay Architecture

The modern shorter GRE features a single 30-minute Analytical Writing task: the "Analyze an Issue" essay.

Time Block	Duration	Key Action Item	Key Deliverable Output
Block 1: Brainstorm & Outline	Minutes 0 – 5 (5 Mins)	Deconstruct prompt; choose clear defensible position; outline 2 body examples	Scratchpad outline with thesis statement and 2 concrete examples
Block 2: Draft Introduction	Minutes 5 – 9 (4 Mins)	Hook, context rephrase, explicit thesis, and brief roadmap of arguments	Complete 3-4 sentence introductory paragraph
Block 3: Draft Body Paragraph 1	Minutes 9 – 16 (7 Mins)	Primary argument with deep historical, scientific, or business evidence	Topic sentence, detailed real-world example, analytical link to thesis
Block 4: Draft Body Paragraph 2	Minutes 16 – 23 (7 Mins)	Secondary argument or counter-argument with effective rebuttal	Nuanced perspective addressing complexity or potential objections
Block 5: Draft Conclusion	Minutes 23 – 26 (3 Mins)	Restate thesis in new words; summarize main reasons; offer broader takeaway	Strong 2-3 sentence concluding synthesis
Block 6: Proofread & Polish	Minutes 26 – 30 (4 Mins)	Check grammar, subject-verb agreement, sentence variety, and spelling	Flawless final essay free of careless typos

Target Length: A competitive 5.0+ essay is typically 450 to 550 words long.

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2. Deconstructing the Official ETS 6.0 Scoring Rubric

Understand how ETS human raters and the e-rater scoring engine evaluate your essay across 4 dimensions.

Scoring Evaluation Dimension	What ETS Raters Look For	How to Secure High Marks (5.0–6.0)
Position & Thesis Clarity	Clear, compelling, and defensible stance on the prompt issue	State your thesis explicitly in the final sentence of your introduction
Depth of Analysis & Insight	Perceptive reasoning that addresses the complexity of the issue	Do not take an simplistic black-and-white stance; acknowledge nuanced tradeoffs
Evidence & Example Relevance	Specific, well-developed examples (history, science, literature, policy)	Use concrete real-world cases (e.g. Galileo, penicillin, Apple, space exploration)
Structure & Coherence	Logical paragraph transitions and signpost words connecting ideas	Use transition phrases: "Consequently", "On the other hand", "Furthermore"
Language & Syntactic Variety	Rich vocabulary, varied sentence structures, and grammatical precision	Combine short impactful sentences with compound-complex sentences

e-rater Scoring: ETS uses both a human grader and an automated AI e-rater; if scores agree, their average is your final score.

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3. The Issue Essay Editing and Polish Checklist

Review your drafted essay in the final 4 minutes using this checklist.

- Check 1: Does every body paragraph have a clear topic sentence directly supporting your thesis?
- Check 2: Are your examples specific? (e.g., Replace "a famous company" with "Tesla's early investment in EV battery infrastructure").
- Check 3: Did you address the counter-argument or nuance? High scores require demonstrating that you understand both sides.
- Check 4: Eliminate repetitive vocabulary (replace "important" with "crucial, vital, indispensable, paramount").